
Four-Day Week Pilot: Final Report

Harbor City Customer Contact Centre

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Summary

From September 2 to November 22, 2024, 34 agents in the Harbor City Customer Contact Centre worked four 8-hour days a week instead of five days, with no change in pay. The pilot lasted 12 weeks. This report describes what the Council measured and what it found.

Main findings

- Productivity, measured as calls answered per agent-hour, rose from 7.1 to 7.4 (a rise of 4.2%).
- Average wait for callers rose slightly, from 48 seconds to 51 seconds. Answer rates and customer satisfaction scores were close to unchanged.
- Sick days per agent fell from 1.2 to 0.9 a month.
- Mondays were the weakest day. The average wait on Mondays rose from 61 seconds to 70 seconds.
- The Council extended the pilot for a further six months, and then changed the working pattern. See section 6.

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1. Background

The Customer Contact Centre answers telephone enquiries about council tax, waste collection, housing repairs, and parking. It is open from 8 AM to 6 PM, Monday to Friday. Before the pilot, agents worked five days a week for 37.5 hours.

In spring 2024 the Council's Executive Board asked the Directorate to test a shorter week. The Board's aims were to improve staff wellbeing, reduce sick leave, and help with recruitment, without making service worse for residents.

2. Methods

Who took part. Forty agents worked in the Centre. Thirty-four full-time agents took part in the pilot. The six part-time agents were not included in the pilot or in the results.¹

Length. The pilot ran for 12 weeks, from September 2 to November 22, 2024. Results are compared with the 12 weeks before it, from June 10 to August 30, 2024.

Working pattern. Agents worked four 8-hour days (32 hours) instead of five days (37.5 hours). Pay did not change. Each agent had a fixed day off, shared roughly equally between Mondays, Wednesdays, and Fridays.

How results were measured. Four measures came from systems and records, so they do not depend on anyone's opinion:

- Productivity: calls answered per agent-hour, taken from the telephone system.
- Service levels: average wait in seconds and the share of calls answered, also from the telephone system.
- Customer satisfaction: the average score (1 to 5) from an automated survey after each call. About 1 caller in 9 completed it.²
- Sick leave: sick days per agent per month, from human resources records.

A short survey of staff was also run in the last week of the pilot.

3. Results

Table 1 shows the main results for the 34 full-time agents who took part. Section 4 gives the results by weekday.

Table 1: Results before and during the pilot

Measure	12 weeks before	12 weeks during	Change
Calls answered per agent-hour	7.1	7.4	+4.2%
Average wait (seconds)	48	51	+3 seconds
Calls answered (share of calls received)	93.1%	92.8%	-0.3 points
Customer satisfaction (1 to 5)	4.1	4.1	No change
Sick days per agent per month	1.2	0.9	-0.3 days

Notes to Table 1.

¹ Results exclude the six part-time agents.

² The customer satisfaction response rate was 11%. Callers who answer such surveys may not represent all callers.

³ Telephone data from October 7 to October 18, 2024 was removed from the "during" figures because of a phone system outage. The "during" figures therefore cover 10 weeks of data.

Productivity rose by 4.2%. The Council believes agents handled calls slightly faster and spent less time between calls. The report does not test why.

4. Customer service and staff views

Service levels held up overall, but not on every day. The table below shows the average wait by weekday.

Table 2: Average wait by weekday (seconds)

Weekday	12 weeks before	12 weeks during
Monday	61	70
Tuesday	50	51
Wednesday	38	40
Thursday	47	49
Friday	44	46

In the staff survey, 29 of the 34 agents who took part said their wellbeing had improved. Five said it was the same. Several agents said Monday mornings felt understaffed because more people had Mondays off than the Centre expected.

5. Limits of the evidence

- The pilot was run in one team in one organization. It had no control group.
- The two periods fall in different seasons. Call volumes in the "before" period were higher in the first weeks because of summer holiday bookings.
- Part-time agents were excluded, and two weeks of data were removed.³
- The customer satisfaction response rate was low.

6. What happened next

The Executive Board reviewed this report in December 2024. On December 2, 2024 it agreed to **extend** the four-day week for a further six months, to June 2025. This was not a permanent change.

In June 2025 the Council changed the pattern. Fixed days off were replaced by a rotating pattern, so that no weekday has fewer than 28 agents on duty. The Council gave two reasons: service levels had stayed close to their earlier levels, and sick leave had fallen. It also said the four-day week had made vacancies in the Centre easier to fill.

The Council will report again after the rotating pattern has run for a full year.

About this report

This report was prepared by the Customer Services Directorate for the Executive Board and published for residents and for other councils. Questions can be sent to the Directorate. All figures in this report come from Council records for the periods stated.